

The Fake Trap

The first traps lived in the answer. The next four lived in you. This last one comes from everywhere else: other people’s AI, pointed at what you see.

AI now makes fake text cheap. Fake images cheap. Fake voices cheap. Fake video is real now, especially in short clips, bad lighting, or anything you scroll past in three seconds. The price of generating something convincing has collapsed, and it’s only going one direction.

Which means the old test you grew up with, ‘does this look real?’, doesn’t work anymore. Looking real is no longer the bar. The new question is harder and more useful: **where did this come from?**

Before you can ask where it came from, you have to notice you should ask. The first tell isn’t in the image, it’s in you. If a piece of content makes you feel surprise, outrage, or vindication strong enough to share it, that reaction is data. The piece was built to land exactly there. The feeling is the cue to slow down and run the checks below.

One more thing before the checks: not every fake comes from AI. A photo can mislead because someone edited it, cropped it, mislabeled it, staged it, dug it up from five years ago, or just shared it out of context. Figuring out which trick was used isn’t the point. The same three checks catch all of them.

THE THREE CHECKS

Run any image, clip, voicemail, or screenshot through these before you react, share, or believe.

CHECK 1 · SOURCE

Where did this come from?

Did this come from somewhere with a reason to know? A direct news source. A person you actually know. A verified account. Or did it come from ‘a friend forwarded it,’ which is the digital version of ‘I heard from a guy.’

CHECK 2 · CONTEXT

Does the surrounding info hold up?

Look around the thing, not just at it. Date, location, what else was happening. A clip of your principal saying something wild on Tuesday afternoon: was your principal even in that meeting on Tuesday? Does the room match where they actually were?

CHECK 3 · CORROBORATION

Does anywhere else show the same thing?

The biggest filter. Real news shows up in multiple places. Real events get talked about by people who weren’t coordinating. If a clip is everywhere on TikTok but nowhere on Google News, that’s information.

One more signal: provenance labels. Some platforms now attach Content Credentials or similar labels showing where an image or video came from and whether AI touched it. Those are useful clues when they’re there. But absence of a label doesn’t prove something is fake, and presence of one doesn’t replace the three checks above.

THE NEW QUESTION

Not ‘does this look real?’ anymore.

Ask where it came from. Look at what surrounds it. Check if anyone else has the same thing. Three questions, every time, before you react.

 **Verify on a different channel from the message.** If a voicemail asks for something urgent, call back on a number you already trust. If a DM does, switch to phone or face-to-face. If a social post claims something big, look for a school announcement, local news, or a trusted adult who would know. Verification has to happen somewhere the sender doesn’t control. And if a message claims real danger, don’t comply through it, but do escalate through someone you trust.

 **Don’t spread it while you’re checking it.** A question mark doesn’t make a repost neutral. ‘Is this real??’ still spreads the clip, the photo, the screenshot, or the rumor. If you’re not sure yet, don’t amplify it. Save it, check it, and wait. The friends who don’t pile on are the ones who get this right.

 **A detector is not a truth machine.** Once your eyes stop working, the next move people reach for is a tool. A detector is another AI making another prediction, with its own blind spots. And since the generation tools keep improving, detection is always playing catch-up. Treat a detector as one clue, never the final word. Whatever the detector says, the next move is still the same: source, context, corroboration.

 **Don’t overclaim in either direction.** Calling something fake without checking is just as wrong as believing it without checking. Both are confident answers without evidence. “Unverified” is the honest position until corroboration shows up.

TRY IT

Time to practice. Each scenario shows something that looks convincing. Pick the move you’d actually make.